Course notes

Key point · Definitions. $u_n \to \ell \in \mathbb{R}$ means that every open interval containing ℓ contains all the terms from some index onwards. We say that (u_n) converges to ℓ. $u_n \to +\infty$ means that for every real number A, there exists an index N such that $n \geq N \Rightarrow u_n \geq A$. $u_n \to -\infty$ means that for every real number A, there exists N such that $n \geq N \Rightarrow u_n \leq A$.

A sequence may have no limit, even an infinite one: $(-1)^n$ oscillates between -1 and 1. Every convergent sequence is bounded, but the converse is false.

Operations and comparisons

For two convergent sequences with limits a, b, the sum tends to $a+b$, the product to ab and the quotient to $\frac{a}{b}$ if $b \neq 0$ (the terms of the denominator are then non-zero from some index on). The rules involving infinity are applied by checking signs. The forms $+\infty - \infty$, $0 \times \infty$, $\frac{\infty}{\infty}$, $\frac{0}{0}$ do not allow a direct conclusion.

Example. $\frac{3n^2-n+1}{2n^2+4} = \frac{3-\frac{1}{n}+\frac{1}{n^2}}{2+\frac{4}{n^2}} \to \frac{3}{2}$. For $\sqrt{n^2+n}-n$, multiplying by the conjugate gives $\frac{1}{\sqrt{1+\frac{1}{n}}+1} \to \frac{1}{2}$.

Key point · Theorems. If $u_n \leq v_n$ from some index onwards and $u_n \to +\infty$, then $v_n \to +\infty$. If $a_n \leq u_n \leq b_n$ from some index onwards and $a_n, b_n \to \ell$, then $u_n \to \ell$ (squeeze theorem). Every increasing sequence that is bounded above converges. Every decreasing sequence that is bounded below converges. This theorem is accepted without proof.

Proof by comparison. For every A, the terms of u exceed A beyond an index N_1. The inequality $v_n \geq u_n$ holds beyond an index N_2. For $n \geq \max(N_1, N_2)$, $v_n \geq A$.

Proof: increasing and not bounded above. For every A, the lack of an upper bound provides N such that $u_N > A$. By monotonicity, $n \geq N \Rightarrow u_n \geq u_N > A$, hence $u_n \to +\infty$. Being unbounded alone is not enough.

Geometric sequences

$$q^n \longrightarrow \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } -1 < q < 1, \\ 1 & \text{if } q = 1, \\ +\infty & \text{if } q > 1. \end{cases}$$

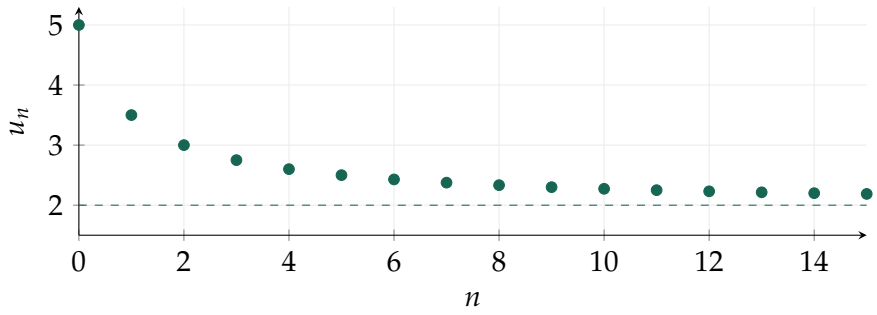
If $q \leq -1$, (q^n) has no limit: alternation for $q = -1$; for $q < -1$, the even and odd subsequences have opposite signs and unbounded moduli.

Bernoulli and the geometric limit. Fix $a \geq 0$. Let us prove $P(n)$: "$(1+a)^n \geq 1 + na$". At index 0, both sides equal 1. Fix $n \geq 0$ and assume $P(n)$ is true. Since $1 + a > 0$,

$$(1+a)^{n+1} \geq (1+na)(1+a) = 1 + (n+1)a + na^2 \geq 1 + (n+1)a.$$

This is $P(n+1)$ since $na^2 \geq 0$. By induction, the inequality is true for every $n \geq 0$. If $q > 1$, take $a = q - 1 > 0$ and compare with $1 + na$. If $0 < q < 1$, apply this result to $\frac{1}{q}$, then take reciprocals. For $-1 < q < 0$, $|q^n| = |q|^n \to 0$ and the squeeze theorem concludes. The case $q = 0$ is handled from index 1 onwards.

> **Method · Recurrence sequence.** For $u_{n+1} = f(u_n)$, establish a bound and monotonicity to prove convergence. If f is continuous at the limit ℓ, passing to the limit gives $\ell = f(\ell)$ (continuity is studied in chapter 6). Solving this equation never proves, on its own, that the sequence converges.



The points get closer to 2 without reaching it: $u_n = 2 + \frac{3}{n+1}$.